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The French were at first able to restrict the Viet Minh guerrillas to remote border areas, but the communist victory in China in 1949 gave the Viet Minh the support of a powerful neighbor.

COLD WAR DIMENSIONS

Better armed and trained, the Vietnamese guerrillas **took the offensive against the French**. At the same time, the Viet Minh leadership openly aligned itself with the communist side in the global Cold War.

US INTERVENTION

In June 1949, the French installed former emperor Bao Dai as head of the state of Vietnam, which was given a degree of independence within the French Union. From 1950, **France obtained American military aid** for its colonial war, which was rebranded as part of the Free World's defense against communist expansion.